

Amen Jalal

Website: amenjalal.com

Email: u.jalal@lse.ac.uk

Department of Economics,
The London School of Economics (LSE),
32 Lincoln's Inn Fields,
London WC2A 3PH, United Kingdom

Placement Director:
Matthias Doepke
Professor, LSE
m.doepke@lse.ac.uk

Education

The London School of Economics, London, UK.

Expected 2026

MRes/PhD in Economics

Fields: Development; Labor; Environmental; Gender

Yale University, New Haven, US.

August 2013–May 2017

B.A. in Economics (with Distinction), *cum laude*

Ronald Meltzer Prize for an Outstanding Senior Essay in Economics (Advisor: Christopher Udry)

References

Nava Ashraf
Professor, LSE
n.ashraf1@lse.ac.uk

Oriana Bandiera
Professor, LSE
o.bandiera@lse.ac.uk

Gharad Bryan
Associate Professor, LSE
g.t.bryan@lse.ac.uk

Robin Burgess
Professor, LSE
r.burgess@lse.ac.uk

Affiliations

Hub for Equal Representation, LSE
Economics of Environment and Energy Programme, LSE
Center for Economic Research Pakistan (CERP)

Grants

Total funding as PI or co-PI: \$1,265,801

€317,000	G ² LM LIC (IZA)	Market Based Solutions to Gender Inequality in Pakistan's Labour Markets
\$253,000	JPAL K-CAI	Heat Insurance at Work
£5,000	LSE-HER	Rebuilding Lives: Integrating Mental Health in Climate Disaster Response
£190,000	IGC	Coping With Catastrophe: Pakistan's 2022 Floods
£5,000	LSE-STICERD	Coping With Catastrophe: Pakistan's 2022 Floods
£90,000	CEPR-STEG	Coping With Catastrophe: Pakistan's 2022 Floods
\$35,000	Harvard University	Coping With Catastrophe: Pakistan's 2022 Floods
\$160,586	IFPRI	What Happens When Cash Transfers Suddenly Stop?
\$50,000	IPA	What Happens When Cash Transfers Suddenly Stop?
£19,500	IGC	Equilibrium Effects of a Billion Trees: Evidence From Pakistan
£20,000	LSE-RISF	The Illusion of Time: Gender Gaps in Job Search and Employment
£5,000	LSE-STICERD	The Illusion of Time: Gender Gaps in Job Search and Employment

Select works in progress

Screening Women Out? Pay Transparency in Job Postings (Job Market Paper)

Outstanding Paper Award – The Discrimination and Diversity Workshop (2025) by Exeter University and European Economic Association.

Abstract: Up to half of the gender pay gap stems from women's sorting into low-wage firms. Do women prefer amenities to wages, or face barriers to search? I tackle this question using data on 29 million job applications from Pakistan's largest job search platform, combined with firm and worker surveys and a field experiment mandating

pay transparency in 20,088 jobs across 8,906 firms. I document that large, high-paying firms are more likely to omit salaries in job ads and less likely to offer flexibility – an amenity women value slightly more. When pay is disclosed, men and women respond similarly to wages. But when undisclosed, behaviors diverge: men search randomly, while women sort negatively on pay. A simple model shows that pay non-disclosure amplifies small gender differences in amenity preferences into large gender gaps in applications. To test whether pay transparency closes these gaps, I randomize mandatory vs. optional pay disclosure on the platform. The experiment leaves large-firm pay and amenities unchanged. Yet women’s applications to these firms increase 95%, and men’s 59%, reversing the gender gap in directed search. This implies women do not knowingly “buy” flexibility with pay; rather, they turn to flexibility when its price is unknown. Meanwhile, firms most exposed to mandated transparency become 30% more likely to disclose pay post-experiment, suggesting they overestimated the costs of transparency.

Immediate Relief, Delayed Recovery: Labor Market Impacts of Natural Disasters

with Pol Simpson

Abstract: Disaster response policies often focus on immediate relief or long-term reconstruction, but what happens in between? We examine how the impacts of Pakistan’s 2022 floods evolve over two years, by collecting panel data from 5,100 low-income households across six districts, and leveraging exogenous local variation in topography and rainfall to estimate causal effects. One year post-floods, a more severe flood shock depleted household assets and reduced labor demand, prompting households to sell assets, commute further for work, and turn to self-employment. They also received more formal and informal aid. As a result, they were able to sustain consumption levels on par with less affected households. However, by year two these patterns are reversed: more flooded households have returned to private employment, working similar hours as less flooded households, but doing so at lower wages. They are also more likely to report reducing consumption and health expenditure, taking new loans and drawing down savings to make ends meet. We also find that more intense floods have persistent negative impacts on physical and mental health - particularly women’s. These findings reveal a medium-run assistance gap: after emergency relief but before long-run reconstruction, households face income risks that standard disaster response overlooks, allowing the effects of climate shocks to persist through labor markets.

The Illusion of Time: Gender Gaps in Job Search and Employment

with Oriana Bandiera and Nina Roussille

Abstract: In countries with low female employment, college-educated women often transition directly from education to homemaking. Does this reflect informed, forward-looking choices or unanticipated constraints? We study this question in Pakistan, where two-thirds of college-educated women remain out of the labor force. Tracking 2,400 college-graduating students, we document that men and women start their search with similar work aspirations, apply at similar rates, and receive comparable numbers of job offers. Yet a 27 pp employment gap emerges within six months post-graduation. This gap stems largely from timing: for women alone, there is a critical window, immediately post-graduation, during which job search is associated with much higher chances of employment. To test whether this relationship is causal, we randomize a modest incentive to apply early. By shifting search into the early window, the intervention raises women’s employment by 20% but leaves men’s employment unaffected, closing a third of the gender gap. Our evidence suggests that applying early enables women to start working before demands from the marriage market arise. Treatment effects are driven by women who underestimate how quickly these demands materialize, revealing an “illusion of time.” This illusion can be persistent since women in our sample recognize the barriers to employment faced by their female peers, but overestimate their own ability to overcome them.

Heat Insurance at Work

with Ashley Pople, Pol Simpson, Eddy Zou and Oriana Bandiera

Abstract: Heatwaves, intensified by climate change, hit the poorest the hardest. Many are exposed to dangerous temperatures through outdoor work or limited access to adaptive resources. In 2024, 37 cities in India surpassed 45 C (113 F), and around 40,000 heat stroke cases were reported. How can social protection systems evolve to address the growing losses caused by extreme heat? We evaluate an innovative intervention in India that offers automatic daily wage payments to low-income workers when temperatures exceed a predetermined threshold. Developed by the Self Employed Women’s Association (SEWA) – a union representing over 3 million informal workers – the scheme is the world’s first parametric heat insurance product targeting earnings loss. We use a randomized

encouragement design, incentivizing SEWA officers to promote enrollment in 2,821 treatment villages, while 2,821 control villages receive no targeted outreach. Panel survey data – combined with high-frequency measurement during the hot season – will allow us to estimate impacts on labor supply, financial decisions, health, consumption, and adaptive behavior. We also assess willingness to pay relative to actuarially fair pricing, providing evidence on the potential for commercial insurance-based heat protection.

Can Market Competition Reduce Corruption?

with Muhammad Haseeb, Alex Quispe and Kate Vyborny

Abstract: Corruption remains a major obstacle to the delivery of public services in developing countries. We study whether competition between service delivery agents can mitigate corruption, leveraging exogenous changes to the market structure of agents responsible for delivering government cash transfers in Pakistan. A reform that increased the market power of these agents led to a 29.1 pp increase in the probability that a beneficiary had to pay an involuntary bribe to access the cash transfer. However, in areas with 1 standard deviation higher competition, this increase in bribe payments is almost completely eliminated. We rule out that mechanisms other than competition drive these results, such as strategic entry, changes in market access, and differences in monitoring efforts or cash recipient characteristics.

Experience

The London School of Economics, London UK

September 2021-2025

Graduate Teaching Assistant:

Microeconomics I	Department of Economics	Bachelors
Macroeconomics I	Department of Economics	Bachelors
Microeconomics	School of Public Policy	Masters of Public Administration
Empirical Methods	School of Public Policy	Exec. Masters of Public Administration / Public Policy
Introduction to Statistics	School of Public Policy	Exec. Masters of Public Administration / Public Policy

The World Bank, Washington DC, US

July 2018–August 2020

Research Assistant, Development Impact Evaluation (DIME) and Identification for Development (ID4D)

Yale University, New Haven, US

May 2016–July 2018

Research Assistant for Ian Ayres (July 2017-18); Christopher Udry (May-July 2016)

Presentations (* scheduled)

2025	Northeastern Universities Development Consortium (NEUDC) Stanford Institute for Theoretical Economics (SITE) - Gender Workshop in Labor Economics: Wages, Employment and Inequality Diversity and Human Capital Workshop IZA PhD Workshop in Labor and Behavioral Economics HEC Economics PhD Conference Warwick Economics PhD Conference Discrimination and Diversity Workshop Women's Employment and Empowerment Workshop European Association of Young Economists (EAYE) Annual Meeting Scotland and Northern England Conference in Applied Microeconomics The Canadian Labour Economics Forum Conference DevPEC G ² LM LIC (IZA) Research Conference	Tufts University* Stanford University Helsinki University of Exeter IZA HEC Paris Warwick University Virtual Royal Holloway University Kings College Crieff Toronto UC Berkeley London
2024	Pathways to Development Conference Inclusive Job Platforms Workshop	Lahore The World Bank
2023	Pathways to Development Conference Transport, Energy and Climate Economics Working Group	Lahore Paris Dauphine University

Environment Camp
2022 CREB External Seminar Series
Pathways to Development Conference

London School of Economics
Virtual
Lahore

Professional Service

Refereeing: American Economic Review; Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization; Economica

Organizing Committee: LSE Environment Week (2023, 2024); LSE Environment Camp (2023, 2024, 2025)

Paper selection: European Association of Young Economists (2025); Pathways to Development (2023)

Mentoring: LSE Application Mentoring Programme (2022, 2023)